

The Corbiani Almanac

MAY 24 - MAY 30, 2026

BBQ at Beth and Matt's — Pulled Pork and Burgers →
Celebration Pizza for the New House

 Elsie's No-Go List: onions and mushrooms mixed together

Week at a Glance

DAY	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sun 05/24 RAIN 64°/52°	BBQ at Beth and Matt's (afternoon)	BBQ at Beth and Matt's — Pulled Pork and Burgers	Chet Faker – Built On Glass
Mon 05/25 LIGHT DRIZZLE 74°/61°	No School — Memorial Day; Sleepover with Isla and Evyln	Gimbap Night (kids) + Dan's Grandma Pizza (adults)	Sister Sledge – We Are Family
Tue 05/26 LIGHT DRIZZLE 77°/64°	No School — Teacher Workday (Student Holiday); Swim practice 6:00 PM; Work block 2:30 PM - 5:00 PM (1:1s + MBR Sync)	Babo Pasta — Egg-Yolk Spinach Tagliatelle with Brown Butter and Parm	Talking Heads – Speaking In Tongues
Wed 05/27 RAIN 78°/62°	No School — Eid al-Adha; House final walkthrough 5:30 PM at 2515 Fowlers Ln; Elsie's first night of swim team 7:00 PM at Hunters Woods Pool	Grilled Cheese and Tomato Soup	Metronomy – The English Riviera
Thu 05/28 SUNNY 78°/59°	House closing 1:45 PM - 3:30 PM at 2503 Fowlers Ln; Swim practice 7:00 PM at Hunters Woods Pool	Pork Chops with Couscous, Carrots, and Peas	Janelle Monáe – The Age of Pleasure
Fri 05/29 SUNNY 76°/49°	Laura drops car off to a friend in DC (afternoon); YAT 4:30 PM - 6:00 PM at 2310 Colts Neck Rd; Swim practice 7:00 PM at Hunters Woods Pool	Buttermilk Pancakes with Sausage and Egg-in-the-Center	Jessie Ware – What's Your Pleasure?
Sat 05/30 SUNNY 67°/52°	YAT 9:00 AM - 12:00 PM at 2310 Colts Neck Rd (tentative)	Celebration Pizza for the New House	Jungle – Volcano

Daily Plan

*From American BBQ to Italian — Neapolitan-leaning, with Chet Faker on
the stereo*

Sunday, May 24

AFTERNOON | BBQ AT BETH AND MATT'S

BBQ at Beth and Matt's — Pulled Pork and Burgers

AMERICAN BBQ

A hosted Memorial Day weekend BBQ at Beth and Matt's. Pulled pork and burgers are the headliners. We bring a thoughtful side or finishing sauce so the family arrives with something special in hand and a quiet thank-you to the host.

pulled pork (host), burgers (host), our contribution: apple-fennel slaw or finishing sauce

Bring an elevated slaw or finishing sauce. Indoor/covered setup likely given the rain.

SERIOUS EATS · 8 TO 10 AS A SIDE SERVINGS · PREP 20 MIN · COOK 0 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Slice the cabbage thin, honey, because nobody invited a lawn mower to dinner. Whisk the vinegar, ketchup, sugar, hot sauce, salt, and pepper until it tastes sharp and a little sweet. Toss the cabbage and carrot with just enough dressing to shine, then let it sit cold so it relaxes. Pack extra dressing on the side and bring pickles because pulled pork loves crunch. Walk in like you helped, because you did.

VARIATIONS

Creamy Classic Coleslaw — Mayonnaise and sour cream make a cooler, richer side for burgers. (recipe)

Simply Recipes Classic Coleslaw — A familiar picnic slaw with cabbage, carrots, and a balanced creamy dressing. (recipe)

South Carolina Mustard Sauce — Bring a tangy mustard barbecue sauce instead of slaw for pork sandwiches. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

Memorial Day is a time to remember people who served and sacrificed. While we eat with friends tonight, what is one everyday freedom or kindness you feel thankful for — something small enough that we might forget to notice it?

Eight-year-olds are ready to move from a holiday as 'a day off' toward the beginning of civic gratitude. Keeping the question concrete — food, friends, safety, a dry place in the rain — helps her build empathy without making the conversation too heavy.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

ACID Cider-Snap Apple Slaw Offering — Bring a crisp slaw of thin-sliced green cabbage, matchstick Granny Smith apple, carrot, apple cider vinegar, a spoon of Dijon mustard, honey, kosher salt, and a thread of extra-virgin olive oil. Keep it chilled and toss once more right before serving.

SAUCE Glossy BBQ Butter Sauce — Bring a small jar of favorite barbecue sauce warmed with apple cider vinegar, smoked paprika, and one tablespoon of unsalted butter whisked in at the end. Label it as a finishing sauce for pulled pork sandwiches.

TEXTURE Sesame Pickle Chip Bowl — Pack dill pickle chips with toasted sesame seeds and cracked black pepper in a chilled serving bowl. Set them beside the buns so people can build crunch directly into sandwiches.

C H E T F A K E R

Built On Glass

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Rainy Sunday hosted dinner calls for warm, smoky soul that fills the kitchen on the drive home, not the BBQ itself.

Monday, May 25 — Memorial Day

NO SCHOOL — MEMORIAL DAY
SLEEPOVER WITH ISLA AND EVELYN

Gimbap Night (kids) + Dan's Grandma Pizza (adults)

KOREAN + ITALIAN-AMERICAN

Two parallel dinners running on the same night. The girls — Elsie, Isla, and Evelyn — get an interactive gimbap rolling station with seasoned rice, julienned carrots and cucumber, spinach, egg ribbons, and bulgogi or canned tuna. The adults eat Dan's grandma pizza: a thick, square Sicilian-style pie with crushed San Marzano tomatoes, low-moisture mozzarella, and basil added at the end.

short-grain rice, nori, carrots, cucumber, spinach, egg, bulgogi beef, all-purpose flour, low-moisture mozzarella, crushed San Marzano tomatoes, basil

Gimbap is hands-on for the kids — set up a rolling station with mats. Pizza dough should rise on the counter through the afternoon.

KING ARTHUR BAKING · 1 HALF-SHEET PIZZA, 6 TO 8 SERVINGS SERVINGS · PREP 25 MIN PLUS DOUGH RISE · COOK 25 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Oil the pan generously and stretch the dough into the corners, then let it rest when it fights you. Scatter low-moisture mozzarella right on the dough so the crust gets that cheesy little armor. Spoon crushed tomatoes over the top in streaks, not a swimming pool, and tuck in fresh basil. Bake hot until the edges are dark gold and the bottom is crisp enough to brag about. Finish with olive oil and more basil, because restraint is for tax forms. Cut squares and let Dan take his victory lap.

VARIATIONS

Food52 Classic Grandma Pizza — A tomato-forward pan pie with a crisp bottom and simple mozzarella topping. (recipe)

Alexandra Cooks Sheet Pan Grandma Pizza — A homey sheet-pan version that emphasizes easy dough handling and bubbly cheese. (recipe)

Basic Square Pan Pizza Dough — Serious Eats style square-pan dough gives a thicker, Sicilian-leaning crust. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

Gimbap has lots of different pieces tucked into one roll. When friends sleep over, what helps everyone feel tucked in and included — choosing a game together, taking turns, saving someone a spot, or something else?

Sleepovers can bring joy and tiny friendship politics in the same pajamas. This gives Elsie language for inclusion, turn-taking, and group belonging before the evening gets overexcited.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Glossy Sesame Gimbap Finish — Season warm short-grain rice with fine salt and toasted sesame oil, then brush the outside of each sliced roll with a whisper-thin coat of toasted sesame oil and shower with sesame seeds just before serving.

TEXTURE Dry the Crunchy Fillings — Pat pickled radish, cucumber sticks, and any cooked spinach completely dry before rolling. Cut every filling into even batons so the kids get one clean snap in each bite instead of a soggy seam.

PREPARATION Grandma Pizza Fried-Bottom Treatment — Oil the sheet pan generously with extra-virgin olive oil, press the dough out by hand, layer low-moisture mozzarella first, then spoon tomato sauce over the cheese in stripes. Bake on the lowest rack until the bottom is audibly crisp, then finish the edges with garlic oil and flaky salt.

SISTER SLEDGE

We Are Family

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Three little girls together for a sleepover on a family-themed holiday — Sister Sledge writes the obvious soundtrack and gives the adults something joyful to cook the grandma pizza to.

Tuesday, May 26

	NO SCHOOL — TEACHER WORKDAY
6:00 PM	SWIM PRACTICE
2:30 PM	WORK BLOCK - 5:00 PM

Babo Pasta — Egg-Yolk Spinach Tagliatelle with Brown Butter and Parm ITALIAN

The family favorite. Homemade egg-yolk and spinach tagliatelle, dressed in nutty brown butter, finished with finely grated Parmigiano-Reggiano and torn sage. It's a recipe that earns its weekly spot because every member of the household actually asks for it.

00 flour, egg yolks, spinach, unsalted butter, Parmigiano-Reggiano, sage, lemon zest
Make the dough in the morning so it rests. Cut tagliatelle right before swim, cook on return.

BBC GOOD FOOD · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 45 MIN · COOK 10 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Blanch the spinach, squeeze it dry like it owes you money, then puree it with egg yolks until bright green. Work it into the flour until the dough is smooth, wrap it, and let it rest before you roll thin sheets. Cut tagliatelle, dust it lightly, and boil it only until tender. Brown the butter until it smells nutty and the milk solids go amber, then catch it before it burns. Toss the pasta with brown butter, pasta water, and a snowy handful of parmesan. Serve right away, because fresh pasta waits for nobody and you made something beautiful.

VARIATIONS

Brown Butter Parmesan Pasta — The Kitchn adds toasted panko for crunch over the same nutty butter and cheese idea. (recipe)

Spinach Mascarpone Tagliatelle — Jamie Oliver folds in mascarpone for a creamy green pasta variation. (recipe)

Eataly Spinach Tagliatelle — A classic fresh spinach pasta base ready for simple butter, cheese, or seasonal sauces. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

Babo Pasta is one of our family favorites. If a favorite meal could give you a power-up before swim practice, what power would it give you tonight — courage, speed, calm, silliness, or something totally different?

Linking a familiar dinner to a physical challenge helps her see routines as support. At 8, playful metaphors make confidence easier to talk about than a direct 'Are you nervous?' question.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Pasta-Water Brown Butter Emulsion — Brown the butter until it smells like toasted hazelnuts, then pull the skillet off the heat. Transfer the tagliatelle directly from the pot into the butter with a splash of starchy pasta water, toss hard, and add finely grated aged Parmigiano-Reggiano in small handfuls until glossy.

TEXTURE Crisped Sage and Parmesan Crumbs — Before saucing the pasta, fry a few sage leaves in the browning butter until crisp, then set them aside. Toast panko in a spoon of the sage butter with grated Parmigiano-Reggiano and scatter over each bowl.

ACID Lemon Zest at the Finish Line — Microplane lemon zest over the plated pasta and add one small squeeze of lemon juice only after the sauce is built and off the heat.

TALKING HEADS

Speaking In Tongues

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A favorite pasta deserves a favorite kind of groove. Talking Heads keep the kitchen alert and the cooking rhythmic — perfect for rolling out dough between tasks.

Wednesday, May 27

	NO SCHOOL — EID AL-ADHA
5:30 PM	HOUSE FINAL WALKTHROUGH AT 2515 FOWLERS LN
7:00 PM	ELSIE'S FIRST NIGHT OF SWIM TEAM AT HUNTERS WOODS POOL

Grilled Cheese and Tomato Soup

AMERICAN COMFORT

The fastest meal of the week — sharp cheddar grilled cheese with mayo-on-the-outside crust, alongside a quick tomato soup built from a can of San Marzanos, sautéed garlic, butter, a splash of cream, and basil. Twenty minutes door to dinner.

sourdough or country bread, sharp cheddar, mayonnaise, canned San Marzano tomatoes, garlic, heavy cream, basil, butter

Mayo on the outside of the bread for an even golden crust. Soup can be made the night before.

DIETHOOD · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 10 MIN · COOK 20 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Start the soup first with garlic, tomatoes, broth, and a splash of cream so it can simmer while you build sandwiches. Butter the bread all the way to the corners, honey, dry corners are a character flaw. Use enough cheese to melt, but not so much the sandwich slides around like a bad decision. Cook low and steady until the bread is deep gold and the middle is gooey. Blend the soup smooth, taste for salt, and give it a tiny pinch of sugar if the tomatoes are sharp. Cut the sandwiches into dunkers and dinner is saved.

VARIATIONS

Smitten Kitchen Soup with Grilled Cheese Croutons — Tiny grilled cheese squares float on tomato soup for a playful bowl. (recipe)

Serious Eats Grilled Cheese — A technique-focused sandwich with crisp bread and an evenly melted center. (recipe)

Cookie and Kate Classic Tomato Soup — A bright vegetarian tomato soup that pairs well with sharp cheddar sandwiches. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

Tonight is your first swim team night — that is a real brave-beginning moment. If future Elsie could send tonight-you one sentence before you jump in, what would she say?

First nights can stir pride and butterflies. Inviting her to imagine encouragement from her future self builds self-talk, confidence, and the sense that she can grow into hard new things.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Mayo-Crisp, Lid-Melt Sandwiches — Spread a thin layer of mayonnaise on the outside of the bread instead of waiting for butter to soften. Cook in a hot skillet over steady medium heat, cover for 60 seconds to melt the cheese fast, then uncover to re-crisp the crust.

SAUCE Soup Pot Cream-and-Basil Finish — Heat the tomato soup as usual, then stir in a splash of heavy cream or whole milk, a pinch of dried basil, and black pepper directly in the pot. No second pan, no ceremony.

TEXTURE Dunking Sticks, Not Triangles — Cut each grilled cheese into four narrow sticks and serve beside small bowls of soup so everyone can eat fast without the sandwich collapsing.

M E T R O N O M Y

The English Riviera

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A light, breezy electropop record matches the speed and brightness of a 20-minute grilled cheese — and gives Elsie a pleasant soundtrack for swim-team excitement.

Thursday, May 28 — Closing Day

1:45 PM | HOUSE CLOSING - 3:30 PM AT 2503 FOWLERS LN
7:00 PM | SWIM PRACTICE AT HUNTERS WOODS POOL

Pork Chops with Couscous, Carrots, and Peas

MEDITERRANEAN-LEANING AMERICAN

Bone-in pork chops seared and finished with a lemon-Dijon pan sauce, served over fluffy couscous studded with sweet peas and caramelized carrot coins. A celebration plate that doesn't take itself too seriously on a day that does.

bone-in pork chops, couscous, carrots, frozen peas, Dijon mustard, lemon, shallot, chicken stock, butter, parsley

Salt the chops in the morning. Sear hot, finish gentle. Couscous takes 5 minutes off the heat.

EATINGWELL · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 20 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Season the pork chops early with salt, pepper, paprika, and a little lemon zest if you have manners. Sear them in a hot skillet until browned, then finish gently so they stay juicy. In another pan, soften carrots in butter or olive oil, add broth, peas, and couscous, then cover it off the heat. Do not boil couscous to death, it is tiny pasta, not punishment. Fluff it with a fork, fold in parsley and lemon, and lay the pork chops on top. Spoon any pan juices over everything and call them family treasure.

VARIATIONS

MyRecipes Spiced Couscous Pork Chops — Warm Moroccan-style spices make the couscous more aromatic. (recipe)
One-Pan Oven Pork Chops and Vegetables — The Mediterranean Dish roasts pork with vegetables for a hands-off variation. (recipe)
Quick Couscous — Food Network keeps the couscous simple so the pork seasoning can lead. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

Today our family officially gets a new house. What is one tiny tradition we should carry into it right away — a first breakfast, a pizza spot, a reading corner, a silly doorway dance, or something only our family would do?

A closing is an adult milestone, but traditions let Elsie feel ownership of the transition. She gets to help define what makes the new place feel like 'ours,' not just watch grown-ups sign papers.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Dry-Brined, Hard-Seared Pork Chops — Salt the pork chops at least 30 minutes ahead if possible, pat them bone-dry, and sear in a very hot skillet until deeply browned. Rest them five minutes before slicing against the grain.

SAUCE Lemon-Dijon Pan Sauce — After the chops come out, deglaze the skillet with chicken stock, scrape up the browned bits, whisk in Dijon mustard, a small knob of unsalted butter, lemon juice, and chopped parsley. Spoon lightly over sliced pork.

ACID Herby Lemon Couscous Lift — Fluff the couscous with a fork, then fold in lemon zest, chopped mint or parsley, peas, carrots, and a thread of extra-virgin olive oil right before serving.

JANELLE MONÂE

The Age of Pleasure

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A celebratory record about arrival, joy, and finally being where you want to be. The right music for closing day.

Friday, May 29

AFTERNOON	LAURA DROPS CAR OFF TO A FRIEND IN DC
4:30 PM	YAT - 6:00 PM AT 2310 COLTS NECK RD
7:00 PM	SWIM PRACTICE AT HUNTERS WOODS POOL

Buttermilk Pancakes with Sausage and Egg-in-the-Center

AMERICAN BREAKFAST-FOR-DINNER

Tall, fluffy buttermilk pancakes, browned breakfast sausage links, and the centerpiece move: a pancake with a sunny egg cooked right into the middle — like an egg-in-a-hole but griddled in batter. Maple syrup, butter, and cold berries on the side.

all-purpose flour, buttermilk, eggs, baking powder, breakfast sausage links, maple syrup, berries, butter

Rest the batter 10 minutes. Cook eggs into the center on lower heat so the white sets while the bottom of the pancake browns.

KING ARTHUR BAKING · 4 SERVINGS · PREP 15 MIN · COOK 25 MIN

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Brown the sausage first so breakfast has a backbone, then keep it warm. Whisk the dry ingredients in one bowl and the buttermilk, eggs, butter, and vanilla in another. Stir them together only until the flour disappears, because pancake batter is not wallpaper paste. Pour big pancakes, cook until bubbles set, then cut a neat center and drop in an egg. Cover the pan so the white sets while the yolk stays friendly. Serve with sausage on the side and maple syrup where it belongs, which is everywhere.

VARIATIONS

Delish Pancake Egg-in-a-Hole — A pancake ring cooks around a whole egg for a dramatic breakfast plate. (recipe)

Tasty Pancake Breakfast Sandwich — Pancakes become the buns for sausage, egg, and cheese. (recipe)

Bon Appetit Sausage Egg and Cheese Pancake Sandwiches — A diner-style stack turns the components into handheld sandwiches. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

Pancakes for dinner means the day is allowed to be a little upside down. What is one thing that went differently than expected today, and how did you handle it?

Busy Fridays can fray everyone. This question normalizes flexibility and helps an 8-year-old notice her own coping skills instead of only remembering what felt rushed.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Rested Batter, Crisp Butter Edges — Mix the buttermilk pancake batter only until lumpy, then let it rest for 10 minutes while the sausage cooks. Cook in a thin film of butter so the pancake edges go golden and crisp.

SAUCE Maple-Pepper Sausage Glaze — When the sausage is browned, brush it in the pan with maple syrup, a splash of apple cider vinegar, and cracked black pepper for the final minute only.

TEMPERATURE Cold Berry Spoon on Hot Pancakes — Toss berries with a pinch of sugar and lemon juice, then spoon them cold over the hot pancake-and-egg stack at the table.

JESSIE WARE

What's Your Pleasure?

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A glamorous, danceable record that turns pancakes-for-dinner into a small Friday night celebration — disco shimmer to match the breakfast-as-treat vibe.

Saturday, May 30 — New House Celebration

9:00 AM | YAT - 12:00 PM AT 2310 COLTS NECK RD

Celebration Pizza for the New House

ITALIAN — NEAPOLITAN-LEANING

Two or three pies cooked as hot as the oven allows, with a high-hydration dough rested overnight. One classic margherita with torn buffalo mozzarella and basil; one with crisp pepperoni cupping pools of grease; and a celebration pie with prosciutto, arugula, hot honey, and a final drift of burrata for the new-house toast.

00 flour, fresh mozzarella, burrata, San Marzano tomatoes, basil, pepperoni, prosciutto, arugula, hot honey

Cold-ferment the dough 48 hours starting Thursday for maximum flavor.

SERIOUS EATS · 2 PIZZAS, 4 TO 6 SERVINGS SERVINGS · PREP 30 MIN PLUS OVERNIGHT DOUGH · COOK 12 MIN PER PIZZA

MAMMA KAREN SAYS

Make the dough the day before if you can, because flavor needs a nap. Stretch it thin but leave a rim, then sauce with a light hand so the crust can crisp. Use low-moisture mozzarella, a little parmesan, and fresh basil after the bake if you want perfume instead of weeds. Bake on a ripping hot stone or steel until the bottom is spotted and the cheese bubbles. Do not overload a celebration pizza, honey, this is dinner, not a garage sale. Slice big, toast the house, and eat while the cheese still pulls.

VARIATIONS

Basic Neapolitan Pizza Dough — A high-heat Neapolitan dough gives a softer, leopard-spotted party pie if the oven setup allows it. (recipe)

Ooni Classic Neapolitan Dough — A pizza-oven friendly formula for quick-blistered crusts and simple toppings. (recipe)

Sally's Homemade Pizza Crust — A forgiving home-oven dough for families who want reliable pizza night results. (recipe)

AT THE TABLE

If this celebration pizza could have one topping for every feeling in our family this week, what toppings would be on it — excited pepperoni, tired mushrooms, proud olives, nervous pineapple?

After a milestone week, playful naming helps her sort mixed emotions without turning dinner into a serious debrief. It also shows her that big happy events can still include tired or wobbly feelings.

Principles content not yet generated for this week.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Stone-Hot Celebration Crust — Preheat a pizza stone or steel at the oven's highest setting for at least 45 minutes. Stretch room-temperature dough gently, keep toppings restrained, and bake until the rim blisters and the bottom is crisp enough to tap with a fingernail.

TEMPERATURE Fresh Burrata After the Bake — Bake the pizza with low-moisture mozzarella, then tear burrata over the pizza after it comes out of the oven. Let the residual heat soften it for one minute before slicing.

SAUCE Hot Honey, Basil, and Flaky Salt Finish — Finish the hot pizza with torn fresh basil, a thin zigzag of hot honey, flaky sea salt, and a thread of good extra-virgin olive oil. Bring it to the table whole before slicing so it feels like a tiny ceremony.

J U N G L E

Volcano

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A dance-floor-bright record for the literal celebration dinner of the week. Volcano is the right kind of loud for a first night in a new house.

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, and beverages

Grocery & Prep

PRODUCE

- spinach (for Babo dough + gimbap)
- carrots
- cucumbers
- fresh basil (large bunch)
- parsley
- sage

PROTEIN

- bone-in pork chops (4)
- breakfast sausage links
- bulgogi beef or canned tuna (gimbap)
- pepperoni
- prosciutto

DAIRY & CHEESE

- buttermilk
- eggs (2 dozen)
- heavy cream
- unsalted butter (2 lbs)
- whole-milk ricotta
- Parmigiano-Reggiano

PANTRY & DRY

- 00 flour (5 lb)
- all-purpose flour
- couscous
- short-grain rice
- nori sheets
- canned San Marzano tomatoes (4)

BEVERAGES

- Lambrusco
- sparkling cider
- espresso (for martinis)
- vodka + coffee liqueur

PREP AHEAD

- ☐ Saturday night: make Sunday's apple-fennel slaw or BBQ sauce.
- ☐ Monday morning: mix grandma pizza dough and let rise 8 hours; cook short-grain rice for gimbap.
- ☐ Tuesday morning: make Babo pasta dough; let rest in fridge.
- ☐ Tuesday night: make tomato soup for Wednesday's grilled cheese.
- ☐ Thursday morning: dry-brine pork chops; start Saturday pizza dough for a 48-hour cold ferment.
- ☐ Thursday night: whisk dry pancake ingredients for Friday.
- ☐ Friday afternoon: pull pizza dough from fridge 2 hours before Saturday's stretch.

Appetizers

Whipped Ricotta with Hot Honey and Lemon Zest

Whole-milk ricotta whipped smooth with olive oil and salt, finished with hot honey, lemon zest, and cracked black pepper. Served with grilled bread.

whole-milk ricotta, hot honey, lemon zest, olive oil, grilled bread

Marinated Olives with Orange Peel and Fennel Seed

Castelvetrano and Kalamata olives warmed in olive oil with orange peel, fennel seed, and a smashed garlic clove.

Castelvetrano olives, Kalamata olives, orange peel, fennel seed, garlic

Salads

SIDE

Arugula with Lemon, Parm, and Olive Oil

The pizza-night classic — peppery arugula tossed simply with lemon, fruity olive oil, and shaved Parmigiano.

Dressing: Lemon juice + olive oil + salt, dressed at the table

Cuts pizza richness on Saturday and pancake sweetness on Friday.

COMPOSED

Apple-Fennel Slaw with Cider Vinegar

Thinly shaved fennel, tart apple, scallion, and parsley with a cider vinegar dressing.

Dressing: Cider vinegar, Dijon, olive oil, honey

The offering for Sunday's BBQ — cuts the pulled pork and burgers.

SIDE

Cucumber and Tomato Salad with Feta

Crisp Persian cucumbers, halved cherry tomatoes, crumbled feta, red wine vinegar, and oregano.

Dressing: Red wine vinegar + olive oil + oregano

Fresh vegetable side that fits Tuesday's pasta and Thursday's pork chops.

SIDE

Spring Greens with Strawberries and Almonds

Spring mix, sliced strawberries, toasted almonds, and shaved manchego with a champagne vinaigrette.

Beverage Pairings

Lambrusco (chilled)

A lightly sparkling, slightly chilled red — the right wine for pizza night and Tuesday's pasta.

Acidic, refreshing, and red enough for tomato sauce and Parmigiano.

Sparkling Cider (for Elsie)

Apple sparkling cider in a wine glass for Thursday's closing toast and Saturday's new-house celebration.

Elsie gets a real toast on the two biggest days of the week.

Espresso Martini

A Friday-night-after-pancakes adult treat, or a Saturday post-pizza pour. Espresso, vodka, coffee liqueur, simple syrup, shaken hard.

A celebration drink with enough caffeine to extend the new-house Saturday night.

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

Parenting Corner

Brave Beginnings, Steady Roots

This week has the shape of a threshold: Memorial Day gratitude, a sleepover, the first splash of swim team, and the official closing on a new house. Elsie may feel proud, silly, tired, clingy, or suddenly very grown-up — sometimes all in the same hour. The quiet parenting thread is to give her little chances to be brave while keeping the family rhythms steady enough that she knows exactly where home is, even as home is changing.

DINNER CONVERSATION STARTERS

SUNDAY — BBQ AT BETH & MATT'S — PULLED PORK, BURGERS, RAINY MEMORIAL DAY WEEKEND

"Memorial Day is a time to remember people who served and sacrificed. While we eat with friends tonight, what is one everyday freedom or kindness you feel thankful for — something small enough that we might forget to notice it?"

Eight-year-olds are ready to move from a holiday as 'a day off' toward the beginning of civic gratitude. Keeping the question concrete — food, friends, safety, a dry place in the rain — helps her build empathy without making the conversation too heavy.

MONDAY — GIMBAP NIGHT FOR THE KIDS DURING THE SLEEPOVER WITH ISLA & EVYLN

"Gimbap has lots of different pieces tucked into one roll. When friends sleep over, what helps everyone feel tucked in and included — choosing a game together, taking turns, saving someone a spot, or something else?"

Sleepovers can bring joy and tiny friendship politics in the same pajamas. This gives Elsie language for inclusion, turn-taking, and group belonging before the evening gets overexcited.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA BEFORE SWIM PRACTICE AT 6PM

"Babo Pasta is one of our family favorites. If a favorite meal could give you a power-up before swim practice, what power would it give you tonight — courage, speed, calm, silliness, or something totally different?"

Linking a familiar dinner to a physical challenge helps her see routines as support. At 8, playful metaphors make confidence easier to talk about than a direct 'Are you nervous?' question.

WEDNESDAY — QUICK GRILLED CHEESE AND TOMATO SOUP BETWEEN THE HOUSE WALKTHROUGH AND ELSIE'S FIRST SWIM TEAM NIGHT

"Tonight is your first swim team night — that is a real brave-beginning moment. If future Elsie could send tonight-you one sentence before you jump in, what would she say?"

First nights can stir pride and butterflies. Inviting her to imagine encouragement from her future self builds self-talk, confidence, and the sense that she can grow into hard new things.

Conversation Starters (continued)

THURSDAY — HOUSE CLOSING DAY CELEBRATION, WITH SWIM AT 7PM

"Today our family officially gets a new house. What is one tiny tradition we should carry into it right away — a first breakfast, a pizza spot, a reading corner, a silly doorway dance, or something only our family would do?"

A closing is an adult milestone, but traditions let Elsie feel ownership of the transition. She gets to help define what makes the new place feel like 'ours,' not just watch grown-ups sign papers.

FRIDAY — PANCAKES FOR DINNER AFTER MOM'S DC CAR DROP-OFF, YAT, AND SWIM PRACTICE

"Pancakes for dinner means the day is allowed to be a little upside down. What is one thing that went differently than expected today, and how did you handle it?"

Busy Fridays can fray everyone. This question normalizes flexibility and helps an 8-year-old notice her own coping skills instead of only remembering what felt rushed.

SATURDAY — NEW HOUSE CELEBRATION PIZZA AFTER YAT 9AM-12PM

"If this celebration pizza could have one topping for every feeling in our family this week, what toppings would be on it — excited pepperoni, tired mushrooms, proud olives, nervous pineapple?"

After a milestone week, playful naming helps her sort mixed emotions without turning dinner into a serious debrief. It also shows her that big happy events can still include tired or wobbly feelings.

Nudges

Give the New House a Kid-Sized Beginning

Closing day can feel huge to adults and oddly abstract to an 8-year-old: papers, keys, logistics, grown-up excitement. Elsie may understand that this is important, but she will likely feel it most through small sensory moments — where her shoes go, which window she likes, what the first snack tastes like in the new kitchen.

Try giving her one tiny ceremony that belongs to her. It can be five minutes: let her choose the first song played in the house, pick the first family photo spot, or decide where a future reading corner might live. The words can be simple: 'This is a big family day, and your ideas belong in this house too.'

1. Hand her the key or let her touch the doorknob and say, 'Want to help us officially welcome the house?'
 2. Offer two or three quick choices: first song, first snack spot, first room to wave hello to, or first family photo.
 3. Name what you notice: 'You are really picturing how we could live here. I love seeing your brain make this place ours.'
 4. End with a repeatable line: 'New house, same team.' Use it later when moving details feel chaotic.
-

Nudges (continued)

Coach the Sleepover Social Weather

A sleepover with two friends is wonderful and also socially complicated. With three children, someone can feel left out fast; with late-night energy, tiny slights can grow dramatic. At 8, Elsie is practicing loyalty, fairness, and how to stay herself in a group.

Before the fun peaks, try a light side-by-side check-in while setting out pajamas or gimbap plates. Keep it casual, not like a lecture. You might say, 'Three-person games can get tricky. If someone feels left out, what is one kind move you can try?' This plants a social tool before she needs it.

1. Ask one low-pressure planning question before guests arrive or while food is being set out.
 2. Brainstorm two rescue moves together: invite someone to choose the next game, switch partners, or make a three-person job.
 3. If drama appears, start with feelings: 'Oof, it feels bad to be the one not picked.' Then ask, 'What would help everyone rejoin?'
 4. The next morning, praise one specific social choice you saw: 'I noticed you made room for both friends on the couch. That was generous hosting.'
-

Nudges (continued)

Turn Swim Butterflies Into a Brave Script

Starting swim team gives Elsie a fresh arena for competence: new coaches, new kids, new rules, and the body-in-motion courage of getting in the water when people are watching. Even active children can feel self-conscious when a familiar skill becomes a team skill.

Try helping her build a tiny script she can carry into the pool. Not a pep talk — just a phrase she chooses. Something like, 'First lap, then I know more,' or 'I can be new and still belong.' When children help choose the words, the encouragement feels like theirs instead of something pasted on by adults.

1. On the drive or while packing her swim bag, ask, 'Do you want a brave sentence for tonight?'
 2. Offer a few options and let her edit them: 'I can try one thing at a time,' 'New things get easier,' or 'My body knows how to learn.'
 3. After practice, ask for one detail instead of a full report: 'What is one thing you know now that you did not know before practice?'
 4. Celebrate effort specifically: 'You got in, listened, and tried. That is how teammates are made.'
-

Connection & Reading

 The Penderwicks: A Summer Tale of Four Sisters, Two Rabbits, and a Very Interesting Boy by Jeanne Birdsall

This warm, funny chapter book sits beautifully at the edge of independence: children making friends, exploring a new place, negotiating sibling-style fairness, and finding courage in ordinary summer adventures. It has enough mischief to feel alive and enough tenderness to feel safe.

It pairs well with a week of new-house imagination, swim-team bravery, and sleepover friendship skills. Read a chapter when the moving talk gets too practical; it gives Elsie a story-world where new places become beloved through small discoveries.

Reflection

At the end of this threshold week, think of one moment when Elsie showed you who she is becoming — maybe hosting friends, stepping toward the pool, imagining the new house, or recovering after a rushed day. What did she not need you to fix? What did she simply need you to witness? You are carrying a lot this week, too; being a steady witness counts as real parenting.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

The Weekly Read

14 articles clipped · Themes, reflections, and something fun

The Tool Is Never Neutral About Care

The AI pieces this week are all arguing, from different corners, that tools do not merely save time; they reorganize responsibility. Google's Antigravity backlash is the warning label: if an interface is buggy, confusing, or greedy for tokens, intelligence behind it will not rescue the experience. Felix Rieseberg's Claude walkthrough offers the happier version, where a floor plan, old receipts, and a \$20 hardware button turn a move into something playful and tractable. Dan Shipper pushes the same thought into the workplace: more automation does not mean fewer humans, but more human judgment placed at the edges of agents, workflows, and shared Slack-like super-agents. Gergely Orosz and Elin Nilsson supply the necessary cold water: AI amplifies the culture it enters, including bad code review, weak mentorship, and management's appetite for velocity over quality. The through-line is not anti-AI; it is anti-magical-thinking. A family closing on a house this week knows this intuitively: the best tool is the one that makes care easier to repeat, not the one that creates new messes faster than anyone can understand them.

The Tool Is Never Neutral About Care *(continued)*

The Pulse: Antigravity 2.0 takes ‘IDE’ out of its new IDE *(technology, ai, developer-tools, google)*

A brief but telling signal that even powerful AI products lose trust when the surrounding experience feels chaotic.

AI's impact on software engineers in 2026: key trends, Part 2 *(technology, ai, software-engineering, management)*

A survey-driven warning that AI magnifies engineering culture instead of magically repairing it.

How I AI: How the engineer behind Claude Cowork actually uses Claude Cowork & What launched at Google I/O 2026 *(ai, product, workflows, google)*

A two-part tour of practical AI habits and Google's I/O launches, with the best insight being that adoption is often psychological before it is technical.

How the engineer behind Claude Cowork actually uses Claude | Felix Rieseberg (Anthropic) *(ai, claudes, home, workflow)*

A practical demonstration of going one abstraction layer up until the computer finds the tedious work for you.

The AI paradox: More automation, more humans, more work | Dan Shipper *(ai, future-of-work, product, automation)*

A bullish argument that agents create more coordination work, not a clean escape from human involvement.

A Home Is a Set of Repeated Invitations

The family and lifestyle pieces are preoccupied with a quieter technology: the ritual. Joanna Goddard's Rec League post celebrates recommendations as a small social currency, the kind of internet joy that says, "I saw this and thought of you." Trinity Mouzon Wofford's favorite-things interview goes deeper, treating a kitchen table, morning candles, and slowed-down travel as ways to build the family culture she did not inherit fully formed. Emily Ley's end-of-school writing brings the ache: elementary years feel permanent while you are packing lunches and planning classroom parties, then vanish into lockers and middle-school hallways. Her summer posts answer that ache with loose structure — tending lists, reading, outside time, camp surprises, hobbies, screen boundaries — not because childhood can be controlled, but because it can be given shape. This is a useful cluster for a week of Memorial Day, swim team, and a new house closing. A home is not made by the keys on Thursday; it is made by the repeated invitations that follow: sit here, eat with us, go outside, bring a friend, tell me what you found.

A Home Is a Set of Repeated Invitations *(continued)*

The 12 Best Recommendations I've Gotten Lately *(family, internet-culture, recommendations, delight)*

A sponsored recommendations list that doubles as a little manifesto for the joyful, human internet.

How Gorgeous Is This \$200 Wedding Dress? *(home, family, ritual, food)*

A favorite-things interview whose real subject is building family culture through meals, pauses, and repeatable beauty.

Rules for raising teenage boys, the introvert's paradox, and my favorite jeans of all time! *(parenting, summer, screens, family)*

A Sunday scroll that turns Maycember exhaustion into a practical case for loose summer guardrails.

A farewell to elementary school *(parenting, school, growing-up, memory)*

A tender reminder that the years of lunchboxes, classroom parties, and tiny sneakers are not as permanent as they feel.

Timeless graduation wisdom, the case for hobbies, and a bubble hem dress I love! *(parenting, graduation, hobbies, summer)*

A busy end-of-school scroll that keeps returning to the same plea: make room for pursuits that are not merely efficient.

Optimism Needs a Place to Land

Packy McCormick's optimism pieces are almost comically abundant: obesity drugs producing bariatric-level results, artificial eggs hatching chicks, AI attacking an Erdős problem, SpaceX imagining orbital compute, SendCutSend reindustrializing custom manufacturing, Isomorphic raising billions to pursue “solve all disease,” Varda testing space drugs, Cerebras and Fervo reopening the IPO window, and Cowboy Space putting data centers in rocket upper stages. It is tempting to read all this as a single fireworks show of techno-cheer. But the better reading is more demanding: optimism becomes useful only when it lands in institutions, factories, trials, supply chains, review processes, and actual bodies. Rust belongs in this cluster because Alice Ryhl's story is the craft counterpart to Packy's exuberance: reliability comes from ownership models, compiler feedback, governance, release discipline, and years of open-source contribution. The future does not arrive because someone names a company Cowboy Space Corporation, though a good story helps capital notice. It arrives when bold quests are paired with boring machinery sturdy enough to survive contact with reality. Memorial Day week is a good time for that distinction: honor the dream, then ask who maintains it.

Why Rust is different, with Alice Ryhl (*software, rust, reliability, open-source*)

A craft-centered argument that reliability is designed into systems long before anyone celebrates the output.

Weekly Dose of Optimism #194 (*science, startups, ai, manufacturing*)

A maximalist catalog of progress, from retatrutide and artificial eggs to orbital compute and AI-assisted mathematics.

Cowboy Space Corporation (*startups, branding, space, venture*)

A weird, funny case study in how differentiation turns ambition into something investors and audiences can remember.

Weekly Dose of Optimism #193 (*biotech, space, ipo, optimism*)

A progress roundup where AI drug design, space manufacturing, cancer treatment, IPOs, and orbital data centers all crowd the same stage.

The Through-Line: *The week's reading keeps returning to one household-sized truth: possibility is only beautiful when it has a container. AI needs review, rituals need repetition, optimism needs institutions, and a new house needs habits before it can become home. Memorial Day asks the family to remember what others protected; swim team asks Elsie to practice showing up; closing day asks everyone to imagine a future and then label boxes anyway. The practical invitation is to make the invisible systems visible: who checks the list, who welcomes the guest, who notices when the tool is helping, who calls time when the screen has won. The question for the week is simple: what are we excited enough to build, and disciplined enough to maintain?*

And Finally... The 1990s Divorced Moms Playlist

The lightest delight this week comes from Joanna Goddard's recommendation roundup, which casually includes "the '90s divorced moms playlist" alongside Trader Joe's hash browns, cats, wild front yards, County Clare, photo matchboxes, and a colorful sandwich spreader. It is a perfect little artifact of the friendly internet: oddly specific, emotionally legible, and impossible not to discuss. It also has the exact right energy for a week of boxes, rain, burgers, swim bags, and house keys — small pleasures passed hand to hand so the logistics do not get the final word. Dinner game: everyone invents a playlist title for a fictional life stage — "Third-Grade Swim Team Swagger," "New House Key Jingles," or "Dad Finds the Tape Gun." Bonus points if the title is so specific that the songs become obvious. Especially if someone can hum the chorus.

Source: *Big Salad*

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The AI paradox: More automation, more humans, more work | Dan Shipper *(Lenny's Newsletter, Sun, 24 May 2026 12:31:49 GMT)*

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The Happiest News *(Cup of Jo (Joanna Goddard), Fri, 22 May 2026 20:17:18 GMT)*

Hi! How's your week going? Today I have a personal update. Not to be "extra," as my kids would say, but I want to shout this from the rooftops... Read more

The 12 Best Recommendations I've Gotten Lately *(Cup of Jo (Joanna Goddard), Wed, 20 May 2026 19:05:41 GMT)*

The 12 Best Recommendations I've Gotten Lately Including a banger 1990s divorced moms playlist. Joanna Goddard and Kaitlyn Teer May 20, 2026 211 48 4 Share Hi!! How is your week going? I'll be sending a personal update this Friday (I'm eager to hear your thoughts), but in the meantime, I'm excited to ask: Have...

Full extracted text: weekly_plans\2026-05-24\news-feed.md

Nutrition

This dinner week is hearty, comforting, and realistic: plenty of protein, plenty of foods Elsie is likely to recognize, and enough celebration to make the week feel fun. The balancing move is not to shrink dinner; it is to let lunches and snacks bring fish/omega-3, legumes, fruit, leafy greens, whole grains, yogurt or fortified dairy, nuts, and seeds. With the five lunches and snack rotation above, the family gets better fiber, steadier energy, more vitamin C for iron absorption, stronger calcium/vitamin D coverage for Elsie, and more potassium to balance the salty restaurant/hosted-style dinners.

LUNCH MOVES

- **Salmon Avocado Crunch Wrap** — Whole-grain wrap with canned salmon or tuna, avocado, cucumber, shredded carrot, spinach, and a lemon-yogurt spread. Pack Elsie's version with mild salmon, extra cucumber, and no onion/mushroom mix. (*omega-3, vitamin D, B12, calcium, fiber, potassium*)
- **Black Bean, Corn & Pepper Lunchbox Bowl** — Black beans, brown rice or quinoa, corn, bell pepper, tomato, avocado, shredded cheese, and lime. Serve components separately for Elsie if she likes a bento style. (*fiber, iron, magnesium, vitamin C, potassium, zinc*)
- **Greek Yogurt Chicken-Salad Bento** — Chicken salad made with Greek yogurt, grapes, celery, and a little mustard, packed with whole-grain crackers, strawberries, and snap peas. No onions or mushrooms needed. (*protein, calcium, B12, vitamin C, fiber*)
- **Hummus & Veggie Pita Box** — Whole-wheat pita triangles with hummus, hard-boiled egg, bell pepper strips, carrots, cucumber, olives, and an orange or kiwi. Kid-friendly because it is dip-and-crunch food. (*fiber, iron, vitamin C, magnesium, zinc, B12*)

SNACK MOVES

- **Greek Yogurt Parfait with Berries, Chia & Granola** — Greek yogurt layered with berries, chia or ground flax, and a small handful of granola. This is the calcium/fiber/omega-3 helper for the week. (*calcium, vitamin D if fortified, fiber, omega-3, vitamin C, protein*)
- **Mandarin Orange + Pumpkin Seed Trail Mix** — A zero-prep fruit plus pumpkin seeds, cashews, walnuts, and a few raisins or dark-chocolate chips. Use a school-safe seed/nut option based on classroom rules. (*vitamin C, magnesium, zinc, omega-3, iron*)
- **Apple Slices with Almond Butter or SunButter** — Apple slices with almond butter at home, or SunButter for a nut-free school snack. Sweet, crunchy, and filling without feeling like homework. (*fiber, magnesium, healthy fats, vitamin E, potassium*)
- **Cheese Stick + Kiwi or Strawberries** — A zero-prep cheese stick paired with kiwi or strawberries. Great for Elsie because calcium and vitamin C arrive in a very familiar snack format. (*calcium, B12, vitamin C, protein*)

Bedtime Story

The Mystery of the Three White Stars

The Mystery of the Three White Stars

The mystery began on rainy Sunday with three white paper stars and no explanation.

Chelsie found them tucked under Sharkie's flipper on the kitchen table while rain stitched silver lines down the windows. Beside the stars was a map of Washington, DC, with tiny circles around Arlington National Cemetery, Constitution Avenue, and the long black wall of the Vietnam Veterans Memorial. At the bottom, someone had written: Find who remembers.

Mr. Bugles sprang up on Chelsie's left hand, wearing one of her old swim goggles like a helmet. "I DO NOT TRUST MYSTERY STARS," he announced. "THEY ARE TOO POINTY."

Mertle, the turtle sock puppet in Chelsie's jacket pocket, raised one stubby arm. "Stars are mostly hot gas at a respectful distance. These appear to be paper. Safer, but less luminous."

Chelsie turned the map over. Nothing. She sniffed the paper. It smelled faintly like tomato sauce and flour, because Daddio had been making grandma pizza dough nearby.

"A clue," Chelsie whispered.

The first circle led only as far as the front porch, where their neighbor Eric was setting a folded flag into a dry spot under the awning. Eric was active in the US Army, and Chelsie knew he did scientific research, though she imagined that meant beakers wearing tiny helmets.

"Excuse me," Chelsie said. "Do you know why someone gave me stars and a map that says find who remembers?"

Eric looked at the stars, then at the rainy street. "I might know one piece," he said. "Memorial Day is when our country remembers the service members who died while serving. For people in the military, it is not just a long weekend. It can be a quiet day, because someone may be thinking of a friend, a teammate, or a name they carry in their heart."

Chelsie went still. The rain sounded softer after that.

"Do you know someone who died?" she asked carefully.

Eric did not look upset that she asked. "Some soldiers do. Some don't. Your family is fortunate not to know someone directly who passed in service. That is a blessing. But the day asks all of us to remember families who do."

He handed her a tiny silver sticker shaped like a microscope. "My Army work is research. Science can serve too. Sometimes protecting people looks like a lab, not a battlefield."

Chelsie put the sticker on the first paper star.

The second clue smelled like pine needles and wet sidewalk. It led to Ed, who was trimming a branch that had drooped after the rain. Ed had served in the Army doing forestry things, which sounded to Chelsie like being a forest detective.

"Forestry things?" Mr. Bugles said, trying to sound official. "I CAN IDENTIFY ONE TREE: BIG."

Ed laughed, but gently. "In the Army, land matters. Trees, trails, maps, camps, erosion, weather. If you do not understand the land, you cannot take care of the people moving across it."

Mertle nodded so hard his cotton shell wrinkled. "Terrain is a sentence the Earth writes in hills and roots."

"That's very fancy," Chelsie told him.

"I contain multitudes," Mertle said.

Ed showed Chelsie how rainwater ran along the curb, carrying little helicopters from the maple tree. "Memorial Day events in DC are part of remembering too," he said. "At Arlington, people visit rows and rows of white stones. At the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier, a wreath is laid for service members whose names we may not know. That matters. Being unknown does not mean being forgotten."

Chelsie pressed one maple seed to the second star and drew a tiny tree beside it.

By Monday morning, the rain had become drizzle. Daddio packed the map into the car, along with sandwiches, apples, and a small container of leftover Babo Pasta because Chelsie believed pasta improved most investigations. They watched part of the National Memorial Day Parade near Constitution Avenue, where bands marched, flags lifted in the damp air, and veterans waved from cars. Nobody was silly about it, but nobody was gloomy the whole time either. It felt solemn, which was Chelsie's delicious new word of the day: serious with love inside it.

At the Vietnam Veterans Memorial, Chelsie saw people touch names on the black stone. Some left flowers. Some stood without speaking. She did not know any of the names, but she understood they belonged to real people, not just history-book words.

"This is a quiet clue," she whispered.

Mr. Bugles whispered back, "I AM BEING MY BEST VOLUME."

The third clue came later in the week, after swim team started Wednesday with wet hair, kickboards, and Chelsie's arms feeling like noodles. On Thursday, the sun finally came out bright and clean for the new house closing. Everyone was celebrating the milestone, but the white paper star still had no sticker, no seed, no answer.

That evening, while Daddio grilled BBQ and the yard smelled like smoke and pepper, Dale stopped by. Dale worked at Amazon now, but he had been deployed to Iraq multiple times protecting the nation. He noticed the blank star in Chelsie's hand.

"That's an important little star," he said.

"It's the last clue," Chelsie said. "I talked to Eric and Ed. I went to the parade and the memorial wall. But I still don't know who wrote find who remembers."

Dale leaned against the deck rail. The sunlight made the grass look new. "When I was deployed, letters and ordinary things mattered. A joke from home. A picture. Knowing people remembered us. But Memorial Day is especially for those who did not come home. It is okay to enjoy your BBQ and your family and your new house. Those good things are part of what people serve to protect. Just make room in the day to be grateful."

Chelsie looked at the blank star. "So it should stay blank?"

"Maybe," Dale said. "A blank star can stand for people whose stories you do not know yet."

After dinner, Daddio brought out the last clue: a small envelope that had been hidden under the pizza peel. Inside was a note in his handwriting.

Dear Investigator, it said, Memorial Day is not a mystery to solve once. It is a remembering we practice. I made the map so you could ask real people real questions.

Chelsie smiled because the mystery had not been hidden treasure. It had been hidden conversations.

She taped the three stars beside the map: Eric's microscope star, Ed's maple-seed star, and Dale's blank star. Then she added one more tiny circle around Arlington and one around the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier.

Mertle performed a small shimmy in the sunset. Mr. Bugles saluted with a swim goggle, then whispered, "THANK YOU," which, for him, was almost ceremonial.

Chelsie decided that remembering was not the same as being sad all day. Remembering was saying names when you knew them, honoring sacrifices when you did not, and noticing how lucky it was to sit at a table with people you loved while the week turned from rain to sun.

Who can we thank for serving, and how can we respectfully remember people whose names or stories we do not personally know?

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